

Media

🕒 Core Theme	Media
≡ Summary	Media encompasses all channels for storing, delivering, and communicating information, including digital/social platforms, broadcast, print, and outdoor formats. Stakeholders such as journalists, editors, and citizen contributors face challenges around bias, language use, and ethical standards, while issues like subjectivity in visual news, AI-generated content, and various forms of government censorship—motivated by control, power maintenance, moral concerns, or public safety—affect the reliability and freedom of media. Regulation methods differ across countries, ranging from internet filtering and licensing to strict film classifications, leading to impacts on free speech, artistic freedom, parental responsibility, and broader societal surveillance.



Media: Media **encompasses the various channels used to store, deliver, and communicate information or data**. It is a broad term that includes print, broadcast, and digital platforms utilised for news, entertainment, and public communication.

- **Digital & Social Media:** Internet-based communication and interactive networks, including streaming services, podcasts, blogs, and social platforms.
- **Broadcast Media:** Electronic transmission of information, primarily consisting of television and radio.
- **Print Media:** Tangible, physical forms of publication such as newspapers, magazines, books, and brochures.
- **Outdoor & Transit Media:** Visual advertising formats such as billboards, digital LED screens, and transit ads

Stakeholders of Media

News reporters and editors:

- In reputable agencies, they practice self-restraint/censorship of personal opinions so that their readers do not suffer a skewed interpretation of the facts. They are bounded by their professional code of ethics they subscribe to, to protect their professional position and status quo.
 - However, inherent issues such as **use of language** naturally reflects the views/opinions of the reporters. Certain words reflect the intensity of the situation, and hence cannot be removed in text. Still, reporters tend to interpret the facts of the situation with minimal adjectives or emotive language.
 - But where do we draw the line between one's personal conviction and opinion and the job they have to fulfill as part of their professional responsibilities?
 - *A journalist at The Wall Street Journal and leader of the Hong Kong Journalists Association, Selina Cheng said she was dismissed after refusing to distance herself from press freedom advocacy work. The case became symbolic of tensions between journalism and political pressure.*
- Citizen journalism has emerged in recent times - news is readily reported by ordinary laymen, who can post their news on many private/public news commentary forums. There is no "code of conduct" for citizens, who can freely make biased and subjective statements in their writing.
 - *In Singapore, Stomp, TheOnlineCitizen, WakeUpSingapore all accept citizen-based submissions of recent happenings in the country, with one's personal opinions readily injected into postings. However, barriers such as POFMA protect false and harmful statements from being posted online, which require one to take down a post and post a statement of fact stating that they told an online falsehood.*

Problems Surrounding Media

Subjectivity of Pictorial/Video News Coverage

Videos/Pictures can be easily edited/intentionally cut to show a different story, whether to imply a falsehood or emphasise on an important message. Problem is exacerbated by the emergence of generative AI content, where models such as Nano Banana Pro, Midjourney etc. allow any user to generate content on the go, making it difficult to differentiate between what is real and what is not

- *On TIME Magazine, reporters placed a picture of an Afghan village girl whose nose was cut off by the Taliban fanatics, all because she fled from her abusive husband. This sparked huge debates of the US's continued involvement in the Iraq war, accelerating the eventual US withdrawal in 2011.*

Media Regulation/Censorship

Why governments censor/control media

- To prevent the media from criticising the government:
 - *Russian legislation has a coined term, the "terrorist danger regime", which prohibits exposing information about scenes/facts of extreme violence which can be put into effect for up to 60 days*
 - *In 2010, Singapore convinced British author Shadrake for contempt, sentencing him to six weeks in jail for "scandalising the judiciary" in his book, where he questioned the impartiality of application of capital punishment on different offenders in Singapore, and asserted that the question of who lives/dies was arbitrary.*
- To maintain its grip on power
 - *The Chinese Communist Party in China denies that police have arrested/tortured anyone who practices Falun Gong, a practice which was coined an "evil cult", though there have been reports by human rights watch groups that those who attempt to practice the movement in China face significant persecution and imprisonment.*
 - *In addition, Chinese-based AI models such as Deepseek, when questioned with the 1989 Tiananmen Square massacre or its stance on the China-Taiwan dispute, will not give any opinion or factual statements on the prompts, and simply say that they are unable to answer the prompt.*
- To prevent offence being given

- *In Japan, it is illegal for any commercial publications to depict the female/male genitalia, and even video pornography routinely depicts explicit sex scenes with the participants' genitalia blurred out.*
- To stop the decline of moral values
- To prevent the worsening of critical situations: Especially during high-risk situations such as conflicts, misinterpretation/overreaction to events by the public could lead to disastrous consequences, with information being used in a wrong manner leading to greater harm.
 - *Live media coverage of the Manila bus hijack in 2010 allowed the hostage-taker to have a bird's eye view of the situation and prepare to react to the exact movements of the police*
 - *The assassination of Osama Bin Laden, the ex-leader of Al-Qaeda, a extremist terrorist group, was hidden from the public until his body was disposed of. This was to prevent the immediate backlash of extremists to prevent potential reprisal attacks.*

How governments censor media

- Saudi Arabia: Public access to/from the Internet has been funnelled through a single government-controlled centre, where the government blocks access to Internet content deemed unsuitable for the country's citizens
- Germany: German phone companies cut off access to all sites hosted on American Internet Service Providers in an effort to bar Germans from gaining access to neo-Nazi propaganda
- Singapore: Media is controlled by a central authority (Information Media Development Authority)
 - Sites that report regularly on issues relating to Singapore and have significant reach are required to apply for individual licences, which must then submit a performance bond of 50k SGD and take down objectionable content within 24 hours of receiving a government order
 - Classification of films are governed by the Films Act of 1981 and go under 6 different ratings
 - General: Suitable for all ages
 - Parental Guidance: Suitable, parents should guide the young

- PG13: Suitable for persons aged 13 and above, parental guidance advised for those under 13
- No Children Below 16
- Mature 18
- Restricted 21
- NAR Not Allowed for All Ratings
 - Issued when
 - The content of the film undermines national interest
 - The film erodes the moral fabric of society
 - Language is religiously profane
 - Real sexual activities are involved (ejaculation, penetration)
 - Explicit promotion and normalisation of homosexual lifestyle/activity - (e.g. #LookAtMe which explored homosexual themes and involved a pastor preaching against homosexuality while acting hypocritically) → Goes against Singapore's traditional, heterosexual nuclear family structure, and such films are refused classification to protect these fundamental values/order to society. May be also because should Singapore allow these films to be distributed locally, it would disrupt the social harmony amongst the racially diverse groups in Singapore.
 - Materials glorifying and encouraging drug and substance abuse
 - Extreme violence and cruelty
 - Scripts of all plays/performances must be vetted by advanced by the IMDA, which has the right to ban a play it views as contrary to the public interest
 - *Homepar by Wild Rice: Initially, the script was approved under a M18 rating. However, the updated script, according to IMDA, glamourised drug abuse, undermined Singapore's strict anti-drug policy, and undermined the confidence in the CNB*

Impacts of censorship on society

- Poses a threat to fundamental free speech rights: Does censoring content truly solve the root cause of the controversy? Wouldn't exposing, confronting and addressing controversial speech test merits of our speech more effectively, instead of filtering such content?
- Suppresses artistic freedom and development due to strict laws
- Shifts responsibility to the government, when it could be shifted towards parents instead (to avoid creating a paternalistic government): It can be argued that it is the responsibility of parents to determine which materials are appropriate for their children
- The accelerating development of technology has made it difficult to block technologies: With the establishment of certain technologies like VPN, dark web accessible via Tor etc. it is easy for a perpetrator's digital footsteps to be untraceable
- Political conflict is encouraged: Omission of certain content from Chinese and Japanese textbooks
- Excessive mass surveillance on society
 - Legal mass surveillance: Public CCTV networks in Singapore, TraceTogether controversy over using data to investigate criminal acts, laws structured in a way that Singapore police has a right to access any information they need (CCTV footage, phone data etc.) for investigation purposes, without a warrant.
 - Commercial mass surveillance: Exchanging personal information and the right to surveil one's shopping habits in exchange for a discount on groceries